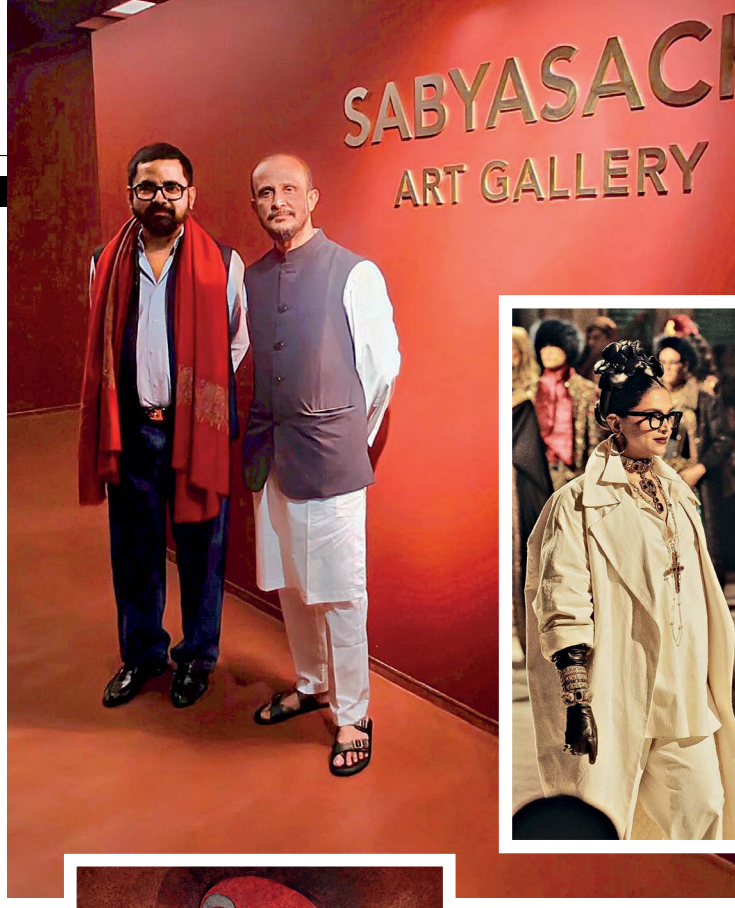
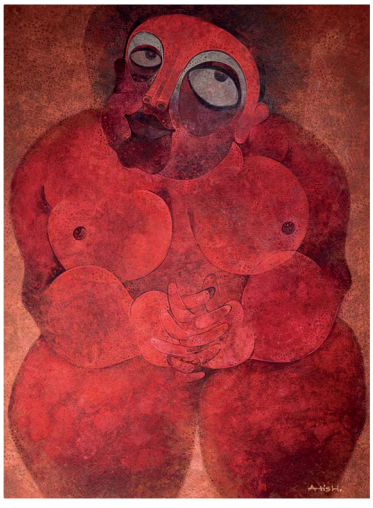




DIFFERENT DESIGNS Clockwise from left: 'Untitled' by Atish Mukherjee at the Sabyasachi Art Foundation; Sabyasachi with the artist; Deepika Padukone walks the ramp at the Sabyasachi 25 Years Show in Mumbai

What's it like to be Sabyasachi Mukherjee? "Tiring!" responds the renowned fashion designer. "You can't let the ball drop when there are so many people depending on you. I'm getting old—my mind is razor-sharp but the body is failing. When there is a conflict between mind and body, you start feeling tired," he confesses.

However, on the night of the launch of décor destination Nilaya Anthology—a 100,000 sq. ft space comprising retail outlets, an art gallery and a co-working space—in Mumbai, where the Sabyasachi Art Foundation has found its permanent home, the designer seemed far from tired, enthusiastically introducing the captivating works of artist-in-residence Atish Mukherjee to the guests in attendance. Sabyasachi established the foundation in 2014 as an initiative dedicated to mentoring and empowering artists from India. "I've been working with Nilaya for a long time and we built the brand together. When I learnt they are opening Anthology, I realised this is the right place to start the Foundation's first art gallery and give Atish his first show," he says, of the décor destination developed by Asian Paints.

"I ALWAYS WANTED THE PRODUCT TO RISE BEYOND THE CREATOR. THERE ARE PEOPLE WHO GET INTO IT TO BE FAMOUS...I JUST WANTED TO CREATE JOBS," SAYS SABYASACHI

For someone who tasted success early—his debut collection shown at Lakme Fashion Week in 2002 opened the fashion world's eyes to a designer to watch out for—Sabyasachi has built a global luxury brand which employs over 3,000 people and has retail stores in Mumbai, Delhi, Hyderabad, Kolkata and New York. You'd think he would be everywhere, hobnobbing at parties or giving lengthy interviews. But the designer chooses to pour his energies into building his brand, which is now 25 years strong.

He puts it down to being a "reticent Bengali". On a serious note, he says if he had to sell himself to sell his designs, he'd rather not sell them at all. "I've always wanted the product to rise beyond the creator. There are people who get into this business because they want to be famous and powerful. I just wanted to create jobs," he says. He confesses that a lot of people wrote him off as arrogant because he's reticent but they realise now that his intent was correct. "I like the work to speak for itself," he shares.

There's a clarity of purpose that shines through when he speaks. "When you're constantly told that you're the best thing after the sewing machine, you start believing in that bulls**t and that is the beginning of your downfall. I had to protect my mind, so I stayed out of people's lives. At the end of the day, they are paying top dollar for my mind. If I let my mind get corrupted by people around me, then I'm not creating a sustainable business," he adds.

In January this year, he celebrated his quarter century in the business with a fashion show in Mumbai that saw models walking down the ramp in a collection that was an extraordinary medley of contrasts in colours, textures and techniques. It was a testament to the diversity of his inspirations and the artistry of his designs. "I think you become relevant when you embrace change. We are more globalised than ever without even having to travel because the internet makes you travel all the time. In the future, there will no longer be American or Indian or African